Name: Jack Fox Date: 10/14/26

002C.2 — Monday October 19 — New Monarchies: General Trends

DO NOW — How did printing help texts circulate?

It created more copies which means more circulation.

THE NEW MONARCHS

INTRODUCTION

- In this lesson, we are going to look at some of the political factors that allowed the Renaissance and Protestant Reformation to take place. We'll focus on roughly 1450-1500.
- We'll also talk about how political developments led to the creation of the modern state as we know it - or at least as something closer to what we know than what existed before.
- Let's start with some general trends, and then focus on specific powers.

GENERAL TRENDS

READING — New Monarchies: power, limits, and state-building

1. Life in the 1300's and 1400's was of course unstable and violent, especially after the devastation of the Black Death across Europe.

2. In response to the chaos and confusion of the times, various kings tried to establish law and order.

3. Politically, there were four important groups: among lay people there were kings, nobles, and commoners, while among the clergy there was also the Church, which often tried to wield political power (it owned land and tried to have a say when it came to what earthly rulers did).

4. Today, when we think of kings and queens, we often think of powerful people wearing fancy crowns who can exert their will to make people do whatever they want.

5. But kings in this area were relatively weak. They were often fighting against the demands of nobles, often expressed through parliaments, commoners who were sometimes restless, and even the Church.

6. Let's first talk about the Church, which obviously could resist the king. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who could hold political power, depending on the circumstances. And then there were high church officials, like cardinals, who were treated like nobility. But it's important to realize that even the Pope, like medieval kings, wasn't as influential as he wanted to be and was at times quite limited in what he could do. He was the spiritual head of the Roman Catholic Church, but he wasn't a ruler who enjoyed obedience under all circumstances. In fact, kings often fought with Popes over both politics and policies within the Church that related to local clergy. And sometimes rulers even intervened over the question of who the legitimate Pope was! There is the notion of a pope and antipope, because throughout the centuries, going back even before the Middle Ages, you sometimes had conflicts between rivals to the papacy for a significant amount of time - one Pope is eventually considered legitimate, the other an antipope.

7. Nobles, more so than kings and clergymen, were consistently powerful - they owned land in the form of estates and had political representation in parliaments, and high-ranking aristocrats served by knights. Nobles were allowed to mete out justice on their own estates - there weren't well-organized court systems to cover their lands.

8. There were two basic groups of commoners:

A. Most were serfs - people who worked for nobles on their estates.

B. There were also townsmen, who of course lived in towns. Medieval towns derived their authority - which was somewhat autonomous - from charters:

i. These were official documents issued by rulers that gave a specific place the ability to rule itself. This was important for medieval towns, just as it would be important for colonies during the Age of Exploration.

ii. Because towns had their own charters, commoners who lived there had the ability to rule themselves independently of nobles, who ordinarily wielded tremendous political power. But it wasn't as if this was self government in the modern sense - towns still fell under the governance of kings, and it wasn't as if townsmen enjoyed wonderful conditions compared to serfs. Still, some serfs used towns as a way of escaping their lords - but if you were caught running away, the punishment could be very severe.

C. Kings and nobles fought over power - and that included the ownership of land, which was the main source of wealth and power. And it's important to note that in feudal Europe, serfs went together with land - if you controlled the land, you controlled the serfs who were legally bound to stay there. This meant that the question of control over estates was critical.

i. Noble families defended inherited rights over land, while kings contested or sought to regulate those rights. Landholding in medieval Europe involved overlapping rights and obligations; private property did not originate at a single moment in this conflict.

ii. And it's important to note that we're talking about actual, violent fighting, even to the point of war. The nobility assembled armies based on knights in shining armor. They were incredibly effective, both because of the protection that their expensive suits of armor provided, and because of their ability to fight on horseback. Kings often had to resort to cheaper options to man their armies against the nobles. That included Pikemen and longbowmen. These soldiers used relatively cheap weapons - long pikes along with big bows and arrows. They required a lot of training, but not a lot of expensive armor and swords.

D. There was also fighting between parliaments, which were controlled by nobles, and towns that fell within areas of their control.

i. Parliaments (which were controlled by nobles) wanted to make laws for the entire lands that fell under their discretion, including towns.

ii. But because local towns had their own charters, they wanted to remain independent. They had local customs and ways of doing things, and they wanted to continue to govern their own affairs as much as possible, without falling under the control of the nobles who happened to control the land in which their town was located.

iii. In this context of struggle over control, a number of city-states in Italy became very powerful on their own and put up a particularly strong degree of resistance to any sort of outside control, including centralized control that might unify them.

a. This was partly because city-state leaders didn't want to give up the power that they had to govern their areas.

b. But it was also because many of the local people didn't want to abandon the customs that they were used to living with.

9. A lot of these tensions were present during the Middle Ages - so a lot of these ideas will be familiar already. But these ideas/tensions become stronger and more pronounced in the Renaissance.

10. One expression that arose in discussions of law during this time was Salus populi suprema lex - "the welfare of the people is the highest law" - this is an important phrase to know.

11. This meant that government (in general) existed for the good of the people, not only as opposed to the leader, but as opposed to the supposed goodness of a particular local custom. (The argument was that you shouldn't simply keep a custom because it's supposedly good for society in the abstract - you need to consider the welfare of the people who live under a particular government.)

Tyranny = bad

A. Perhaps the most powerful implication of this notion was that tyranny was simply unacceptable. This built off of an older Roman notion, popularized by Cicero, but it emphasized it and justified it with the full force of Christian context. If the government became a tyranny, it was both proper and legal to overthrow it. Examples of thinkers who argued for this were: John of Salisbury (12th century), Aquinas (13th century), and Dante's opposition to the Pope's political power (14th century). If a tyrant is making war against the people, then he's making war against God Himself. This outlook developed from the way in which the Bible describes the enemies of the Jewish people as making war against God Himself.

B. This led the nobility to place restrictions on rulers throughout Europe. The most famous example was the Magna Carta, which forced King John to concede some of his power in 1215.

C. But it's important to realize that realistically, it's not as if kings were being overthrown all the time. Despite the theoretical right to overthrow a tyrant, order was considered to be extremely important. One way of looking at it was that you should only overthrow a government if it was better to have no government at all; because if you went ahead and tried to depose a tyrant, there could be an incredibly violent struggle in order to do so, as well as war over who should succeed him. Everyone was understandably afraid of anarchy. That was meant to prevent people from rashly disrupting social order - they had to carefully think through whether a revolt was worth it, since it might produce terrible bloodshed.

12. Some rulers, feeling that they had a right to do what they pleased, argued for the principle of Quod principi placuit legis habet vigorem, "what pleases the prince has the force of law."

A. These maxims (sayings) can support competing emphases in political argument: public welfare and princely lawmaking. They are not a complete description of two uniform constitutional systems.

B. So, we have two opposing trends - either rulers must act for the good of the people, or they can do what they like.

13. The practice of referring to kings as "your majesty" and the use of the term "sovereign" for a ruler both come from this time period, where you had kings trying to bolster their authority. In the case of "majesty," this was a revival of a Roman practice.

14. Note: The trend of individual leaders appealing to the people over nobles and institutions (it happened before with the populares in Rome, and we'll see it again). Kings often did this to gain power. You may remember the "bread and circuses" from Julius Caesar. Kings did this to gain popular approval and/or were pandering.

15. And the term "majesty" wasn't the only thing that was revived from the Roman Empire in order to try to give rulers a sense of authority. The Holy Roman Empire continued to play an important role in European power politics. Let's talk about it for a moment.

CUE / CONCEPT	ONE PHRASE — towns, infantry, both Latin maxims
Problem after crisis Why did stronger government appeal to people?	• _____ _____ • _____ _____ • _____ _____ _____
Four political forces kings · nobles · commoners/towns · Church	• _____ • _____ • _____
Nobles / land / parliaments / local justice	• _____ • _____ • _____
Towns / charters / commoners Why might towns support kings?	• _____ • _____ • _____
Military change knights vs. pikemen / longbowmen	• _____ • _____
salus populi suprema lex public welfare as a limit/justification	• _____ • _____

CUE / CONCEPT	ONE PHRASE — towns, infantry, both Latin maxims
quod principi placuit legis habet vigorem prince's will as law	• •
Majesty / sovereignty / popular appeal	• •
Overall trend Stronger territorial monarchy—but not yet unlimited absolutism	• • •

KEY TERMS

1. Serf
2. Charter
3. Pikemen
4. Longbowman
5. Salus populi suprema lex
6. Quod principi placuit legis habet vigorem
7. Sovereign

SUMMARY

1. In the era of the "New Monarchs" there was a three-way conflict between kings, nobles, and commoners, with the Church and papacy also important political actors.

2. The role of commoners was important. Towns with charters possessed additional rights and often found royal law and order useful against private noble warfare.

3. These conflicts strengthened arguments about the welfare and dignity of individuals as well as arguments for stronger public authority.

4. There was a shift toward more centralized territorial governance; nobles and clergy remained powerful, but monarchies increasingly built institutions that could act across a kingdom.

8. Independent medieval towns and Renaissance cities remained important political and economic actors across Europe.

9. These political changes formed part of the setting in which the Protestant Reformation would unfold.

Palmer & Colton Reading and Evidence Questions — The New Monarchies

II. The New Monarchies — P&C pp. 67–74

4. Discuss — From pp. 67–68, explain why stronger kings could appeal to townspeople even while reducing the role of parliaments.

5. Write two sentences — What do the two Latin maxims reveal about the justification and danger of stronger monarchy?

QUIZ NOTICE — Monday 10/26:

> 002Q: printing; Erasmus/Christian humanism; Faust; Cusa and limited human creativity; North/Italy emphasis; infantry; Ferdinand and Isabella; Habsburg dynasty versus imperial centralization; charters; limits on stronger monarchy; one Northern/New Monarchy comparison.
>
> 10 MC + one 2-point response; 12 core points + 1 optional bonus; 15 minutes; closed notes.

HOMEWORK — for Tuesday 10/20: Bring 002C.3 and your 002C.2 notes. Complete Question 5 only if unfinished; no additional chart rows or new reading. Quiz 002Q Monday, October 26; study 002SG1.

NEXT HANDOUT — Tuesday October 20: 002C.3 — https://docs.google.com/document/d/1cQqBi5DOXJcndpI1rUBW3SZud1MQWuX-/edit

Sources: Palmer & Colton, pp. 67–74.